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THE PROBLEM OF EMPTY NAMES¹

Marga Reimer

I. Identifying the Problem

Consider the following hypothetical conversation:

A: Who or what is Vulcan?

B: Vulcan is a planet situated between Mercury and the sun.

C: No, it isn't. Vulcan doesn't exist.

Intuitively, *A*'s question makes perfect sense; it appears to be a straightforward query concerning the identity of Vulcan.² And, intuitively, while *B*'s response to *A*'s question is meaningful though false, *C*'s response is both meaningful and true.

Such intuitions are of special interest to the contemporary semanticist, as they appear to be at odds with the currently popular doctrine of Millianism. According to this doctrine, the meaning (or 'semantic value') of a proper name is simply its bearer. Suppose that we combine Millianism with the commonly held view that declarative sentences can be said to express *propositions*. The resultant view then claims that proper names contribute their bearers, and *only* their bearers, to the propositions expressed by the (declarative) sentences in which they occur. Thus, on such a view, the name 'Kripke', as it occurs in the sentence 'Kripke is a philosopher', contributes *the man himself*—and nothing more—to the proposition expressed by that sentence.

But what of so-called 'empty' names—names like 'Vulcan', 'Santa Claus', and 'Sherlock Holmes'? Such names are commonly thought to be without bearers; they refer to nothing. Suppose for the moment that this is so.³ Then, according to Millianism, such names are without semantic values. They accordingly make *no* contribution to the propositions expressed by the sentences in which they occur. How, then, is the Millian to make sense of the intuition that the sentences uttered by *B* and *C* in response to *A*'s query, express meaningful, *truth-evaluable*, propositions?

This problem might be referred to as 'The Intuition Problem', as it asks the Millian to account for certain *intuitions* that appear to be at odds with his analysis of empty names.

¹ I would like to thank two anonymous reviewers of this journal for helpful comments on an earlier draft of this paper.

² Nineteenth century astronomer Leverrier hypothesised that there was a planet between Mercury and the Sun causing perturbations in Mercury's orbit. He stipulated that 'Vulcan' was to name this planet. It turned out that there was no such planet.

³ As we shall see when we get to a discussion of Salmon's (1998) view, this is a controversial assumption.

For if Millianism is correct, then empty names have no meanings; they have no ‘semantic values’. But if empty names have no meanings, one might expect the propositions expressed by sentences containing them to also lack meanings, or at least truth values. Yet intuitively, such propositions (whatever their content) are both meaningful and truth-evaluable. How, then, is the Millian to account for this intuition?

The Intuition Problem is associated with a second problem facing the Millian—that of providing some sort of specification of the propositions expressed by sentences containing empty names. This problem might accordingly be called ‘The Problem of the Proposition Expressed’. It is a ‘problem’ simply because it is not obvious just how the Millian should characterise propositions (and associated truth conditions) of the sort in question. Generally speaking, subject-predicate sentences containing *non-empty* names (in subject position) would appear to express so-called ‘singular’ propositions: propositions containing the names’ bearers as constituents. Such is, at any rate, the view of the Millian who countenances propositions. Such a proposition might thus be specified by an ordered pair consisting of the name’s bearer and the property ascribed to that object or individual. Thus, the proposition expressed by sentence (1) might be specified as in (2):

(1) Kripke is a philosopher.

(2) <Kripke, being-a-philosopher>

Such a proposition would be true just in case Kripke is a philosopher.

But what if the name is *empty*, that is, without a bearer? How is the Millian to specify the proposition expressed in such cases—if, indeed, there is a proposition expressed in such cases? And, if there is a proposition expressed, what are its truth conditions—if, indeed, it has any such conditions?

These two problems are *distinct* problems. ‘The Intuition Problem’ asks the Millian to reconcile intuitions concerning the truth-evaluability of propositions expressed by sentences containing empty names with the view that such names make no propositional contribution. ‘The Problem of the Proposition Expressed’ asks the Millian to specify the propositions expressed by sentences containing empty names, together with any associated truth conditions. It is thus somewhat misleading to talk of ‘*the* problem of empty names’. Such talk reflects the fact that the two problems are often conflated. It is often assumed that any adequate solution to The Problem of the Proposition Expressed (‘PPE’ from here on) will yield a solution to The Intuition Problem (‘IP’ from here on). That is, it is assumed that an account of the former sort should attempt to *preserve* (rather than ‘explain away’) our semantic intuitions. Such an assumption implies that the proposition expressed *is* the proposition intuited (grasped, understood)—the proposition we (unreflectively) judge to be both meaningful and truth-evaluable.⁴

Initially, such an assumption might seem rather plausible. Consider, for instance, a Millian account of subject-predicate sentences containing *non-empty* names. According to

⁴ Jerrold Katz (1994) makes this assumption when he assumes that apparently true negative existentials like ‘Santa Claus does not exist’ are ‘obviously’ true. What is obvious, if anything is, is that we *take* such sentences to literally express truths, not that they actually do. Braun (1993), whose view is discussed below, comes very close to making this assumption.

such an account, the proposition expressed by such a sentence is *about* the name's bearer: that is, it contains that object or individual as a *constituent*. Our semantic intuitions—intuitions of the sort appealed to Salmon (1986), Soames (1987) and others—are *preserved* on such an account. For that account claims, in effect, that the propositions expressed by sentences containing names are what they intuitively seem to be: propositions *about* the particular objects and individuals that bear the names in question. Such preservation is a large part of what makes the Millian account so appealing. However, not all plausible accounts of the proposition expressed will preserve our unreflective intuitions. For there is always the possibility that the proposition intuited is not the proposition (if any) that is expressed. And sometimes, this possibility appears to be a probability. Grice (1975) has shown us as much. To illustrate: when I say to you 'I have one daughter' it seems, unreflectively, as though I have said—*literally* said—that I have *exactly* one daughter. But for reasons that I won't go into here, it is not implausible to suppose that this is merely what I *meant*; what I actually *said* would be true just in case I have *at least* one daughter. Such cases suggest that we are sometimes apt to misidentify what is communicated with what is literally said (that is, the proposition expressed).

It is thus a mistake to simply assume that any plausible solution to PPE will yield a solution to IP. However, if a proposed solution to PPE does not yield a solution to IP, the advocate of the former should be prepared to provide some sort of solution to IP: that is, he should be prepared to account for those intuitions that are not preserved by his solution to PPE. For surely, if that solution claims, in effect, that we say something other than what we intuitively think we say when we utter sentences containing empty names, then some sort of explanation is in order.

Although IP and PPE are distinct problems, the attempt to solve the one is generally accompanied by an attempt to solve the other. In cases where the solution to PPE yields a solution to IP, the fact that this is so is typically regarded as *evidence* for the proposed solution to PPE. The rationale behind such an assumption is the idea that, other things being equal, the more intuitive account is the more plausible account. In cases where the solution to PPE fails to yield a solution to IP, a solution to the latter is generally proposed. And, more often than not, it is in terms of the Gricean distinction between *what is said* and *what is communicated*. We will see one such solution below.

There are three things that I would like to accomplish in this paper. *First*, I would like to propose and motivate solutions to the pair of problems that constitute what I have referred to as 'the problem of empty names'. *Second*, I would like to show the superiority of the proposed solutions to some of the available alternatives. And *third*, I would like to draw some methodological conclusions based on what will have been learned from an examination of 'the problem of empty names'.

II. The Problem of the Proposition Expressed

It would be natural for the Millian to approach the problem of empty names by first proposing a solution to PPE, and to then work backwards, as it were, explaining any unintuitive consequences of his solution, thereby solving IP. After all, to solve PPE involves specifying the propositions that are expressed by sentences containing empty names, and the Millian *already* has a view as to the semantic value of empty names—which is that they have none. He would thus appear to have a head-start on a solution to

PPE. So, let's begin by looking at some possible solutions to PPE, and let me begin with a presentation of my own solution to this problem.

There is a sense in which the solution to PPE might appear to be obvious. For the Millian is committed to the view that *empty* names—names *without bearers*—are without semantic values. He is thus committed to the view that such expressions contribute *nothing* to the proposition expressed, assuming that a proposition *is* expressed.⁵ Assuming this to be the case, the Millian would appear to be committed to the view that sentences containing such names express propositions that are in some sense *incomplete*. The propositions expressed by sentences containing empty names might be said to contain 'gaps'—'gaps' ordinarily filled by objects and individuals of the sort contributed by proper names.

Such propositions have recently been discussed in the literature. Not surprisingly, they have been discussed in connection with the problem of empty names. They have been referred to variously as 'incomplete propositions' (Adams and Stecker, 1994) 'unfilled propositions' (Braun, 1993), and 'structurally challenged propositions' (Salmon, 1998). Let's consider just how such propositions might be specified. To do this, let's return to the case of Vulcan. Consider sentences (3) and (4):

(3) Vulcan is a planet between Mercury and the sun.

(4) Vulcan does not exist.

If indeed there are empty names—names without bearers—then the name 'Vulcan' is surely one of them.⁶ Assuming that the name 'Vulcan' is in fact empty, the propositions expressed by sentences (3) and (4) might be represented as in (5) and (6), respectively:

(5) <(), being-a-planet-between-Mercury-and-the-sun>

(6) <<(), existence> NEG>

What the unfilled positions (represented by empty parentheses) make clear is the fact that a semantic value—that corresponding to the subject term—is 'missing'. Or, more precisely, what the unfilled positions make clear is that a semantic value is not supplied by the subject term of the sentence in question. We can then generalise from the Vulcan sentences to generate a tentative solution to PPE: the way to specify the proposition expressed by a sentence containing an empty name in subject position, is to leave the position reserved for the semantic value of the subject term unfilled. Such gappy propositions are arguably *not* truth-evaluable. For there is no logical subject of predication, and so nothing to which the predicate phrase can be correctly or incorrectly applied.

⁵ The Millian who denies that a proposition is expressed might provide one of two reasons for doing so: (i) there are no such things as propositions or (ii) sentences containing expressions without semantic values fail to express propositions. Such a theorist will still have to provide a solution to 'The Intuition Problem', which might be redescribed as the problem of accounting for the intuition that, in assertively uttering sentences containing empty names, we appear to be able to say things that are true or false.

⁶ Salmon (1998) disagrees.

The motivation for any such view is straightforward: it is consistent with the doctrine of Millianism, according to which the semantic value of a name—if it has one—is nothing other than its bearer. Indeed, it seems to me that the proposed rendering of sentences containing empty names is simply an *application of*, rather than an *extension of*, the doctrine of Millianism, when this doctrine is combined with the view that sentences containing empty names express propositions. For if the semantic value of a name is one and the same as its bearer, then if a name has no bearer, it has no semantic value. Assuming that sentences containing empty names express propositions, such propositions are going to have to be ‘gappy’ in the sense just described. Thus, arguments for Millianism are indirectly arguments for the proposed account of empty names—which is, as just noted, simply an application of Millianism to empty names.

The apparent difficulty with the proposed solution to PPE is that it fails to preserve our intuitions concerning the truth-evaluability of the propositions expressed by sentences containing empty names. For the propositions expressed by sentences like (3) and (4)—whatever their correct analysis turns out to be—certainly *seem* to be truth-evaluable. But that they are truth evaluable, is contrary to the predictions of the proposed solution to PPE. How, then, are such intuitions to be explained by the Millian? As we will see when we turn to The Intuition Problem, there is a plausible explanation of these intuitions, one that appeals to our pre-theoretical beliefs about reference to nonexistents.

It is not surprising to find that similar solutions to PPE have been proposed by a number of Millians. For as I have said, there is something almost obvious about the proposed solution to PPE—given the assumption that sentences containing empty names (in subject position) express propositions. However, it is perhaps somewhat surprising to find that some of the details of the proposed solutions to PPE vary, and vary in ways that appear to be significant.

I would now like to look at some of these alternative solutions to PPE. I would then like to consider the various factors that motivate these alternative solutions. It will emerge that the differences among the possible solutions to PPE (including the proposed solution to that problem) result from different approaches to IP: The Intuition Problem. Thus, in adjudicating between the various possible solutions to PPE, it will be necessary to examine the ways in which the advocates of those solutions handle IP.

So, let’s have a look at some alternative solutions to PPE. Three such solutions have recently been proposed in the literature: one by Fred Adams and Robert Stecker (1994), one by David Braun (1993), and one by Nathan Salmon (1998). All three are similar in spirit, though not in detail. And, as will soon emerge, some of the differences in detail are not insignificant.

(a) Adams and Stecker

I would like to begin with Adams’s and Stecker’s proposed solution to PPE. Their solution is, so far as I can tell, most like the one that I have proposed. Indeed, the only substantive difference between the two solutions appears to concern the treatment of (true) negative existentials. However, as we shall see, this difference has a direct bearing on Adams’s and Stecker’s solution to IP.

According to Adams and Stecker (1994), sentences containing empty names express ‘gappy’ or ‘incomplete’ propositions, propositions which have no truth values. Rather

than specifying directly what these propositions are, Adams and Stecker specify them indirectly, by specifying the logical form of the sentences that express them. Such sentences are represented as having the logical form of so-called ‘open sentences’—sentences containing unbound variables, the values of which are, in principle, indeterminate. A sentence like (3) might thus be represented as in (7); a sentence like (4) might be represented as in (8).

(7) x is a planet between Mercury and the sun.

(8) There is no x such that $x=y$.

Because the logical forms are specified in terms of open sentences, the ‘gappy’ propositions expressed are claimed, by Adams and Stecker, to be without truth values. Their solution thus fails to preserve intuitions of truth-evaluability, for the propositions that would be expressed by assertive utterances of sentences (3) and (4) would seem to be false and true, respectively. However, these intuitions are, as we shall see presently, ‘explained away’ via Adams’s and Stecker’s solution to IP.

The primary motivation for Adams’s and Stecker’s solution to PPE is that it is consistent with Millianism. For it represents empty names as being without semantic values. An additional advantage, so they suggest, is to be found in their accompanying treatment of (true) negative existentials, sentences like (4). For this treatment is consistent with the standard treatment of existence in terms of existential quantification.

Despite the similarity between the proposed solution to PPE and that of Adams and Stecker, there is an important difference concerning their treatment of negative existentials, of sentences of the form *a does not exist*. To say that *a* does not exist is, for Adams and Stecker, to say that there is no thing such that it is identical to *a*. Thus, on their view, to suppose that there are things (such as Vulcan) that do not exist is *literally incoherent*. In contrast, on the view that I have proposed, to say that *a* does not exist is to say simply that it is not the case that *a* exists. In particular, I do not commit myself to the standard interpretation of the existence predicate in terms of existential quantification, as do Adams and Stecker. Thus, my view is *consistent with* the view that there are things (such as Vulcan) that do not exist. Thus, the two views in effect give different analyses of the incomplete proposition expressed by sentences containing empty names when the sentences in question are negative existentials.⁷ The importance of this difference will become clear once we turn to The Intuition Problem.

(b) Braun

Now let’s move on to Braun’s solution to PPE. According to Braun (1993), sentences containing empty names express ‘unfilled’ propositions—propositions containing ‘gaps’. So far, Braun’s view is no different from either the proposed view, or that of Adams and Stecker.⁸

⁷ This can be seen by comparing analysis (8) with analysis (6).

⁸ Braun’s account is, however, narrower in scope, as it is not intended to apply to the names of fictional characters.

Sentences (3) and (4) are, on Braun's view, represented as expressing the unfilled propositions specified in (9) and (10).

(9) $\langle \{ \}, \text{being-a-planet-between-Mercury-and-the-sun} \rangle^9$

(10) $\langle \langle \{ \}, \text{existence} \rangle, \text{NEG} \rangle$

(The use of curly braces rather than parentheses represents a purely stylistic variant between Braun's representation of sentences containing empty names and the proposed representation.) Braun, however, assigns truth values to incomplete propositions. In this way, his solution to PPE differs from that of Adams and Stecker. Truth values are assigned by Braun in accordance with the general principle that,

If P is a proposition having a single subject position and a one-place property position, then P is true iff the subject position is filled by one, and only one, object, and it exemplifies the property filling the property position. If P is not true, then it is false.¹⁰

The motivation for Braun's solution to PPE is two-fold. *First*, it is consistent with Millianism and *second*, it preserves intuitions of truth-evaluability. It claims, in effect, that we are correct in thinking that in assertively uttering sentences containing empty names, we manage to *say* (and not just *communicate*) things that are true or false. In this regard, Braun's solution to PPE has an apparent advantage over both the proposed solution and that of Adams and Stecker, according to which the incomplete propositions expressed by sentences containing empty names (in subject position) are without truth values.

(c) *Salmon*

Salmon (1998) claims that names traditionally treated by semanticists as empty are in fact non-empty.¹¹ Names of all things hypothetical, mythical, and fictional really do have bearers according to Salmon. Those bearers are abstract objects; they are man-made artifacts.

Thus, on Salmon's view, sentences (3) and (4) express run-of-the-mill singular propositions, propositions that might be specified as in (11) and (12).

(11) $\langle \text{Vulcan}, \text{being-a-planet-between-Mercury-and-the-sun} \rangle$

(12) $\langle \langle \text{Vulcan}, \text{existence} \rangle, \text{NEG} \rangle$

The motivation for Salmon's account is three-fold. *First*, it is consistent with Millianism. *Second*, it preserves at least some of our intuitions. For instance, sentence (3) comes out

⁹ In order to avoid irrelevant complications involving the representation of multiple-argument predicates, I have represented (with Braun's permission) the predicate in question as simple rather than complex.

¹⁰ Braun (1993), p. 464.

¹¹ On Salmon's (1998) view, the only genuinely empty names are those introduced into the language with stipulations to the effect that they are empty or are empty given certain conditions.

false, just as we are unreflectively inclined to believe. (Note, however, that Salmon's view has the counter-intuitive consequence that apparently true negative existentials like (4) are false.) *Third*, Salmon's account is coupled with an allegedly well-motivated ontology, according to which such things as Vulcan, Santa Claus, and Sherlock Holmes, really do exist—albeit as abstract objects.

In defence of the claim that the ontology in question is indeed a well-motivated one Salmon claims,

The main reason to acknowledge the existence of fictional characters and the like ... is that doing so provides the most plausible explanation for the truth (which is presumed) of such sentences (which we frequently do utter) as 'There is a fictional detective who (according to the story) is addicted to cocaine, but there is, at least as yet no fictional detective who (according to the story) is addicted to banana peels'—and other sentences (i.e., as uttered by authors, literary theorists, film critics, etc.) making apparent reference to fictional characters.¹²

When asked to identify those individuals who allegedly 'presume the truth of' sentences of the sort in question, Salmon responded by claiming that,

... acknowledging fictional characters provides the most plausible explanation of the truth of certain sentences which *I* am presuming true. I think it is a useful philosophical methodology to presume the truth of certain sentences that we utter when we mean to be speaking truthfully and literally UNLESS there are philosophically pressing and plausible reasons for doubting their truth.¹³

So, how do we choose from among these four solutions to PPE? Before making that choice, it will be necessary to examine more carefully the various factors that respectively motivate each of the four solutions. And, in order to do that, we must look at how the proponents of those solutions attempt to handle The Intuition Problem.

III. The Intuition Problem

Let me begin by first introducing, and by then arguing on behalf of, my own solution to The Intuition Problem.¹⁴

As *speakers* of language—and not as *philosophers* of language—we assume that reference to nonexistents (things that do not exist) is possible. This is not—or should not be—a controversial point. For it's an easily recognisable empirical fact. Suppose, for instance, a speaker sincerely utters sentences (13) and (14):

(13) Santa Claus is jolly.

¹² Salmon (personal correspondence, 1998).

¹³ Salmon (personal correspondence, 1998).

¹⁴ I discuss and defend this solution in much greater detail in my (2001) 'A "Meinongian" Solution to the Problem of Empty Names'.

- (14) Santa Claus does not exist.

Then, unless she has engaged in some philosophical reflection, thereby ‘discovering’ the problem of empty names, she will surely take herself to be referring to (and saying something about) Santa Claus, *even if she believes that he does not exist*. Just imagine that you ask her, ‘When you say that *Santa Claus* is jolly, and when you say that *Santa Claus* does not exist, just whom do you take yourself to be referring to?’ What’s her response likely to be? Surely something like: ‘I’m referring to Santa Claus, of course. To whom did you think I was referring, *The Easter Bunny*???’ This suggests that, *unreflectively*, there is simply no problem with the idea of referring to things that we don’t think of as existing—things such as Vulcan, Santa Claus, and Sherlock Holmes. If there were such a problem, then we wouldn’t utter sentences like (13) and (14) because they would sound funny. Now it does sound funny, even without thinking about it, to say such things as ‘It’s raining, but I don’t believe it’. So, we don’t say such things—ever, not even if we are pathological liars. It does *not*, on the other hand, sound funny to say that Santa Claus is jolly, or that Santa Claus does not exist. Indeed, saying such things seems to involve saying things that are truth-evaluable and sometimes even true.

But, one might wonder, could the speaker *really* take herself to be referring to *Santa Claus*, even if she believes, even if she goes on to *say*, that he does not exist? Well, that’s just crazy, one might think. For it would imply that she believes that there are things, things to which she can refer, that don’t exist. But to suppose that an ordinary speaker might have such beliefs is not at all crazy. The supposition that there *are* things that don’t *exist* may, in some sense, be ‘crazy’ (perhaps it’s ultimately incoherent). But that is emphatically *not* the supposition that I am making. The supposition that I am making is simply that the speaker is *unreflectively inclined to suppose* that she can refer to things that don’t exist. This does *not* require that there are things that don’t exist; it does not even require that the supposition that there are such things be coherent. At most, it requires that the speaker thinks, *unreflectively*, that there are things that don’t exist, and that she can refer to such things. Indeed, it is an easily recognisable empirical fact that speakers of the language *do* assume that there are things that exist *and* things that do not exist. For how else could we account for the fact that we *routinely* utter sentences like (15) and (16) and in doing so, take ourselves to be speaking *both literally and truthfully*:

- (15) There *is* a mythical figure named ‘Santa Claus’—but he doesn’t *exist*, the whole thing is just a myth.
- (16) There *is* a fictional detective named ‘Sherlock Holmes’, but he doesn’t *exist*—he’s merely fictional after all.

And, if speakers of the language *unreflectively* assume that there are things that do not exist, then why resist the idea that they *also* assume that such things can be *referred to*? If we think that we can *specify* examples of things that don’t exist (Vulcan, Santa Claus, and Sherlock Holmes), then *of course* we think that we can refer to them—how else could we purport to specify them?

So, here, in essence, is my solution to IP: as speakers of the language, we *unreflectively* assume that there are nonexistent and that reference to them is possible.

We thus have intuitions to the effect that, in uttering sentences like (13) and (14), we manage to refer to such things, and to say true or false things about them. Clearly, this solution is compatible with Millianism and, in particular, with the view that empty names contribute *nothing* to the proposition expressed.

'Fine', you might say. But that only shows that those of use who have not engaged in the relevant sort of reflection are inclined to think that there are things that do not exist, and that such things can be referred to. So perhaps you have explained away the intuitions of the unreflective. But those of us who *have* done some reflecting realise, of course, that things that do not exist are nothing at all, and so cannot be referred to. The difficulty is that *we* still have those same stubborn intuitions—intuitions to the effect that sentences like (3) and (4) are capable of expressing meaningful, *truth-evaluable*, propositions. Not only that, but some of us reflective sorts are *Millians*, and thus are not willing to countenance a Fregean or Russellian description account of empty names. So, *our* intuitions are left unexplained on the proposed view.

My response is a simple one. I favour Millian accounts of empty names over description (and other) accounts, and I am sceptical about the idea that there are nonexistents to which we can and do refer. But when I say—in ordinary, everyday, conversation—that Santa Claus, Vulcan, or Sherlock Holmes does not exist—I take myself to be denying the existence of certain things—things to which I can and do refer. I thus assume, *if only for that one unreflective moment*, that I am referring to such things, things which I believe *not* to exist. And it is in such unreflective moments that the intuitions that generate what I have called 'The Intuition Problem' come to the fore. This is not to say that, *in moments of reflection*, I cannot rid myself of this assumption. Indeed, as a Millian disinclined to countenance things that do not exist, I can 'see' that, in assertively uttering sentences containing empty names, I am not actually referring to anything at all. However, these reflective thoughts of mine are 'theoretical' (rather than 'pre-theoretical') and are thus, in an important sense, question-begging. For they presuppose a certain metaphysical *theory*: that there is nothing that does not exist. They are thus irrelevant to what I have termed 'The Intuition Problem'—a problem which involves making sense of our *pre-theoretical* intuitions concerning the truth-evaluability of sentences containing empty names.

So much for my proposed solution to IP. How does it bear on my proposed solution to PPE? My solution to IP is consistent with my ontologically cautious Millian solution to PPE, according to which names like 'Vulcan', 'Santa Claus' and 'Sherlock Holmes' refer to nothing, and so have no semantic values. We certainly *talk as though* there are things that bear these names—and, in doing so, we take ourselves to be speaking both literally and truthfully. For that reason, I hesitate to commit myself to the standard treatment of existence in terms of existential quantification, according to which claiming that *a* does not exist amounts to claiming that there is nothing identical to *a*. I don't mean to suggest that there are no instances in which such an account might be appropriate—sentences like the infamous 'Tame tigers exist'—seem to suggest a standard quantificational reading of existence. My point is simply that I don't want to commit myself to the view that such a reading is *invariably* the correct one. Moreover, even if there are no such things as things that do not exist—even if the idea is somehow incoherent—it is *language*, and not *reality*, that we are analysing when we look at the problem of empty names. And the linguistic data suggest that, whatever we mean by 'existence', we do *not* regard it as something that is had by all things. This suggests that it might be a mistake to employ the standard

quantificational treatment of existence to *all* natural language sentences containing the grammatical predicate ‘exists’.¹⁵ For this reason, I view my solution to PPE as superior to that of Adams and Stecker, if only because it appears to be a more cautious solution.

As to the intuitions that serve as the basis for the intuition problem, I believe that they are adequately explained (or ‘explained away’) by my solution to that problem. They are the inevitable result of an undeniable empirical fact—that speakers of the language are unreflectively inclined to suppose that there are things that do not exist, and that such things can be referred to. There is therefore no need to make the unintuitive move of assigning truth values to the incomplete propositions literally expressed. For this reason, I consider my solution to PPE to be superior to David Braun’s.

As to Salmon’s argument for thinking that such things as Vulcan, Santa Claus, and Sherlock Holmes really do exist: I don’t buy it. It is certainly true that we take ourselves to be speaking both literally and truthfully when we utter such things as,

- (17) There is a fictional detective named ‘Sherlock Holmes’.

But we also take ourselves to be speaking literally and truthfully when we utter such things as:

- (16) There is a fictional detective named ‘Sherlock Holmes’ *but he does not exist*—he is merely fictional, after all.

So, while Salmon claims that the way we talk suggests that the bearers of fictional names *really exist* (qua abstract objects), I claim that the way we talk suggests that, while the bearers of such names can be referred to, they *do not exist*.¹⁶ And if such things don’t exist (and never have existed and never will exist), it is no longer clear that there are grounds for supposing that they can serve as propositional constituents. That is why I choose to specify propositions containing names like ‘Vulcan’, ‘Santa Claus’, and ‘Sherlock Holmes’ with unfilled positions.

(a) *Adams and Stecker*

Let’s now consider what Adams and Stecker have to say about The Intuition Problem. According to Adams and Stecker, the intuitions that generate IP are the predictable result of conflating *what is said* and *what is communicated*. Consider, for instance, an assertive utterance of (4).

- (4) Vulcan does not exist.

¹⁵ An account of the sort provided by so-called ‘free logics’ would clearly be appropriate. Such logics are ‘free’ in the sense that they are free of the classical assumption that every term denotes something that exists. For a clear and accessible discussion of free logics, see Read (1994), chapter 5.

¹⁶ Salmon (1998, pp. 303–4) suggests that, in making such claims, the speaker is using ‘exists’ non-literally to mean (roughly) ‘exists as depicted’. The sort of move strikes me as *ad hoc* given the availability of the proposed account, according to which the existence predicate is used literally.

Such an utterance plausibly communicates a proposition to the effect that there is no planet situated between Mercury and the sun—at least none that is responsible for any perturbations in Mercury’s orbit. We recognise this proposition as true, and because we mistake it for what is said, we think that something true has been *said*.

The problem with this account is that it does not withstand informed reflection. For even *after* we are apprised of the distinction between what is said and what is communicated, we *still* want to say that, in sincerely uttering sentences containing empty names, we *say* and do not just *communicate*, propositions that are truth-evaluable. The speaker who assertively utters sentence (4) for example, will probably *not* be persuaded that her conviction that she has *said* something true is the result of her confusing what she *meant* with what she actually *said*—not even after a careful reading of Grice (1975). She will surely respond with something like, ‘Look I’m talking about *Vulcan*—the planet hypothesised to explain Mercury’s orbital perturbations—and what I am *saying*—and not just attempting to *communicate*—is that *Vulcan* does not exist. That’s it!’

What makes some pragmatic explanations of what appear to be semantic facts appealing, is that, once we hear them, we are inclined to say: ‘Oh yes, now I see that I was confusing what was said with what was communicated’. We are not, however, likely to say such things upon being presented with an account like Adams’s and Stecker’s. (At least Braun, Salmon, and I have failed to be convinced.)

(b) *Braun*

Braun’s solution to PPE yields, or appears to yield, a solution to IP. It is, as noted above, problematic to assign truth values to unfilled propositions. However, Braun is of the opinion that our intuitions of truth-evaluability are simply too strong to be explained away via the distinction between what is said and what is communicated. As he puts it, the main problem with such an explanation is that it is unlikely that it can adequately account for our judgments about truth. When we assertively utter the sentence ‘Santa Claus does not exist’—we thereby *say* something true is just too obvious to be denied. Such intuitions should accordingly be *preserved*, rather than ‘explained away’. Hence, the assignment of truth values to unfilled propositions, the result of which is a solution to IP: we have the intuitions that we do, because those intuitions are intuitions of what we *say*, and what we *say*—and not just what we *communicate*—is truth-evaluable.

But does Braun’s solution to PPE *really* preserve our intuitions? His theory does appear to capture the intuitive *truth values* of sentences containing empty names. Intuitively, while an utterance of (3) would express a falsehood, an utterance of (4) would express a truth—and that’s what Braun’s account predicts.

(3) Vulcan is a planet between Mercury and the sun.

(4) Vulcan does not exist.

So, it does appear to preserve *truth* intuitions. It would thus appear to solve the Intuition Problem. However, it does so only at the expense of the problematic assignment of truth values to ‘gappy’ propositions. More importantly, Braun’s solution does not preserve, or otherwise account for, what might be called ‘content’ intuitions. Specifically, it does not account for the intuition that, in assertively uttering sentences containing empty

names, we appear to be saying things *about* the bearers of those names—we appear to be expressing so-called ‘singular’ propositions. And these content intuitions are ones that Braun himself implicitly acknowledges. He claims that our intuitions concerning ‘aboutness’ help motivate the view of propositions as structured entities—a view that Braun not only finds plausible, but that he presupposes throughout his discussion of empty names. When we utter the sentence ‘Kripke is a philosopher’ we appear, intuitively, to say something *about Kripke*. And, when we utter the sentence ‘Sherlock Holmes is a fictional detective’ we appear, intuitively, to say something *about Sherlock Holmes*. And it seems to me that these are intuitions that need to be somehow accounted for. Thus, perhaps the Intuition Problem should be revised so as to include content intuitions in addition to truth intuitions. However, Braun’s solution to PPE does not preserve or otherwise account for such ‘content’ intuitions. And so that solution does not generate an adequate solution to The ‘Revised’ Intuition Problem—for while it preserves *truth* intuitions, it does not preserve or otherwise account for *content* intuitions.¹⁷ There is accordingly no good reason—at least none that is offered by Braun—to assign truth values to unfilled propositions. For the assignment of truth values to such propositions does not adequately account for our semantic intuitions concerning sentences containing empty names. And it is only because he believes otherwise that Braun is led to make such an assignment.

(c) *Salmon*

According to Salmon, in uttering sentences like (18),

- (18) There is a fictional detective who (according to the Conan Doyle stories) is addicted to cocaine.

we appear to be speaking literally and truthfully. And there are, Salmon believes, no compelling reasons for supposing that this is not the case.

We are thus free to conclude that there *really exist* such things as fictional characters, hypothetical planets, mythical bearers of Christmas gifts, and the like. Such things can accordingly serve as the constituents of propositions expressed by sentences containing what appear to be empty names. Such propositions, being filled, rather than unfilled, are truth-evaluable. In this way, Salmon purports to provide a solution to The Intuition Problem.

The problem with this line of reasoning is that there are *other* sentences with the same right to be presumed true, that lead to the opposite conclusion. Consider sentences like (16):

- (16) There *is* a fictional detective named ‘Sherlock Holmes’, but he does not *exist*—he is merely fictional, after all.

¹⁷ In my (2001), I argue that any theory that legitimately counts the preservation of truth intuitions as a theoretical virtue, must also preserve, rather than explain away, content intuitions. The rationale here is that truth intuitions are based on content intuitions; we have the truth intuitions that we do *because* we have the content intuitions that we do. Specifically, we assign truth values to the intuited content.

Such talk suggests that, as speakers of the language, we unreflectively assume that there are things that exist and things that do not. So, if language is, as Salmon appears to think, a *prima facie* guide to reality, then there is no more reason to think that Sherlock Holmes exists than to think that he does not. And, in that case, it would be premature, to say the least, to represent the propositions expressed by sentences containing empty names as literally expressing singular propositions containing ‘real abstract objects’ as constituents.

IV. Concluding Remarks

Although we began by looking at The Problem of the Proposition Expressed and then turned to The Intuition Problem, proceeding the other way around might have been more logical. Initially, moving from PPE to IP seemed the natural thing to do, as the solution to PPE seemed obvious—at least in holding that propositions expressed by sentences containing empty names are, in a sense, ‘incomplete’. But we have just seen that the various solutions to IP have implications for the solution to PPE. Thus, differences in the details of the solutions to PPE can be explained, at least in part, by differences in the treatment of IP. We saw, more specifically, that a plausible solution to IP does *not* (*contra* Salmon) require us to include Vulcan, Sherlock Holmes, and Santa Claus among those things that really exist; nor does it require (*contra* Braun) that we assign truth values to unfilled propositions. The proposed solution does, however, suggest (*contra* Adams and Stecker) that we remain neutral on the semantic treatment of the existence predicate. It is, after all, *language*—and not *reality*—that we are interested in analysing when we try to understanding the workings of empty names. And language—the way we talk—suggests that we view existence as something that not everything has. This does not mean, of course, that there are some things that do not exist—only that we are unreflectively inclined to think that this is so.

These are, admittedly, rather narrow conclusions; when you examine a narrow philosophical problem, you generally end up with narrow philosophical conclusions. But sometimes broader, methodological, conclusions can be drawn from an examination of comparatively narrow problems. Kripke (1977) made this clear when he drew conclusions about the nature of linguistic communication from his careful examination of Donnellan’s referential/attributive distinction. I believe that some broader conclusions can in fact be drawn from the preceding discussion of the problem of empty names.

In fact, there appear to be at least *three* methodological conclusions that might be drawn from our discussion of empty names.

The *first* conclusion concerns *pragmatic* explanations of what initially appear to be *semantic* facts. Such explanations typically claim that certain intuitions are the result of confusing what is said with what is communicated, wrongly identifying the latter with the former. This is precisely the sort of explanation that Adams and Stecker give of intuitions to the effect that, in assertively uttering sentences containing empty names, we manage to say things that are true or false. Instances of such explanations are quite common in the philosophy of language literature. Stephen Neale (1990), for instance, invokes such an explanation in explaining away the intuitions surrounding the referential use of definite descriptions, and Nathan Salmon (1986) invokes such an explanation in explaining away the intuitions of opacity associated with belief ascription sentences containing co-referring

names. Sometimes such explanations can be quite persuasive—indeed, they can be downright compelling. But such explanations do have their limits. If, after being apprised of the Gricean distinction, we *persist* in claiming that what we *said* had such-and-such semantic properties, then such an explanation is rightly regarded with suspicion. It will have all the appearance of being *ad hoc*.¹⁸

The *second* conclusion concerns the distinction between content intuitions and truth intuitions. The point is that *both* sorts of intuitions need to be dealt with by the semanticist. If such intuitions are not *preserved* by the theory, they should at least be explained away. The importance to semantic theory of content intuitions is suggested by the fact that Millianism—a plausible though not uncontroversial theory—gains much of its appeal from such intuitions. That's surely why it's sometimes referred to as a 'naïve' theory—intuitively, it just seems right. It's not just that we can imagine counterfactual scenarios in which Aristotle had none of the properties standardly attributed to him—it's that in saying such things as 'Aristotle was fond of dogs' we seem to be saying something *about Aristotle*—and not about whoever had such-and-such attributes. The point is that, if such content intuitions are not preserved, they need to be explained away. They cannot simply be ignored by the semanticist.

The *third* conclusion concerns the distinction between semantic appearance and semantic fact. One must be wary of presuming that sentences have the semantic properties they unreflectively appear to have. This has been clear at least since Russell (1905). But actually following advice in this case is considerably more difficult than thinking that one is doing so. Consider, again, a sentence like (18):

- (18) There is a fictional detective who (according to the Conan Doyle stories) is addicted to cocaine.

This sentence certainly *seems* to be true; and if we presume it to be so, then perhaps we will end up with an ontology like Salmon's—or at least like Meinong's.¹⁹ But then, we are going to have to deal with such sentences as (19):

- (19) Fictional characters do not exist.

which seem every bit as true as sentences like (18).

In sum. Although the problem of empty names might initially strike one as an uninteresting, because narrow, philosophical problem, several important lessons can be learned from an examination of its proposed solutions.

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¹⁸ This point has been made before. See, for instance, Richard (1990), p. 125.

¹⁹ Meinong's ontology, in contrast to Salmon's, includes things that do not exist.

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